

Friday, 21 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Overcast

20° 14°

BIRMINGHAM

Light drizzle

19° 13°

MANCHESTER

Light drizzle

18° 12°

GLASGOW

Overcast

18° 12°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1 A man accused of people smuggling has been arrested and charged after being exposed by a BBC investigation.

Twana Jamal Khdir, who was the subject of a major BBC report, now faces immigration offences. This follows a lengthy investigation into illegal crossings.

CRIME · UK

2 After a long dry spell, heavy thunderstorms are continuing to sweep across the UK, bringing a risk of floods.

Although thunderstorm warnings have now expired, the persistent rain means many areas could still see flooding. It's a stark contrast to the recent very dry weather.

WEATHER · UK

3 Doctors are warning that vaping could lead to serious health harms for children, potentially acting as a gateway to smoking.

A new report from the Royal College of Paediatrics and Child Health has raised significant concerns. They are urging for stricter regulations and more awareness.

HEALTH · UK

4 The government has announced plans to clean up three of the worst illegal waste dumps in the country.

These sites, located in Kent, Surrey, and West Yorkshire, reportedly contain a staggering 22,000 tonnes of waste. It's a major effort to tackle environmental blight.

ENVIRONMENT · UK

5 The Prime Minister has stated that Harry and Meghan's security arrangements are a private matter, wishing them well on their UK return.

The Duke and Duchess of Sussex are expected back in the UK later this month. Security has long been a sensitive point for the couple.

ROYALS · UK

What's coming up

1 **Reading Festival has been granted a music extension, despite some noise concerns, ahead of its opening next week.**

Charli XCX, rapper Dave, and Chase & Status are set to headline the festival, which kicks off on Thursday. It's great news for music fans heading to the event.

ON AIR – Are you heading to Reading Festival? What act are you most excited to see?

MUSIC · AUGUST

2 **African musical icon Angélique Kidjo has made history by receiving a star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame.**

The 66-year-old from Benin was celebrated for her incredible contribution to music. She passionately declared that "without Africans, no music is possible on this planet."

ON AIR – What's your favourite Angélique Kidjo track? She's truly a global superstar!

AWARDS · NOW

3 **The National Television Awards have made history with their first ever all-female shortlist for the drama acting award.**

The five-strong list features brilliant actresses Ella Bruccoleri, Sheridan Smith, Ruth Jones, Vicky McClure, and Judy Parfitt. It's a fantastic recognition of female talent.

ON AIR – Who do you think deserves to win the NTA for Best Drama Performance this year?

AWARDS · COMING UP

4 **Ariana Grande is bringing her tour to the UK, with the first of ten dates kicking off in London.**

The pop superstar will be performing across the capital before taking a break from public life. Fans are eagerly anticipating her return to the stage.

ON AIR – Are you going to see Ariana Grande in London? What's your favourite song of hers to hear live?

MUSIC · THIS WEEK

5 **Bella Ramsey, star of 'The Last of Us', has admitted they wish they had been a more rebellious teenager.**

Ramsey is starring in a new film about a cancer survivor finding friendship and freedom at 'chemo camp'. It sounds like a heartwarming story.

ON AIR – Do you agree with Bella Ramsey? Was your teenage self rebellious, or did you wish you had been?

FILM · COMING UP

On the schedule

1 **England bowlers Ollie Robinson and Josh Tongue have put their side in control on day one of the first Test against Pakistan.**

Both bowlers took five wickets each at Headingley, helping England bowl Pakistan out for 171. England closed on 112-2, just 59 runs behind.

ON AIR – What a start for England! Do you think they can push for an early victory in this Test?

CRICKET · UK

2 **Celtic have taken a huge step towards the Champions League group stage with a comfortable win over LASK.**

Two stunning goals from Camilo Duran helped secure a commanding first-leg play-off lead against the Austrian side. The Scottish champions are now in a strong position.

ON AIR – Can Celtic now go all the way and secure their place in the Champions League?

FOOTBALL · UK

3 **Liverpool midfielder Curtis Jones is set to join Inter Milan after the Italian club agreed a £30m deal.**

The move will see Jones leave Anfield for Serie A. It's a significant transfer as the new season approaches.

ON AIR – How do you think Curtis Jones will fare in Italy? Is this a good move for him and Liverpool?

FOOTBALL · UK

4 **Max Verstappen has signed a new contract with Red Bull until 2030, revealing he was "closer to retiring" than changing teams.**

The F1 world champion's long-term commitment to Red Bull ends speculation about his future. It's a huge statement of intent from Verstappen.

ON AIR – What do you make of Verstappen's comments? Is he right to commit his long-term future to Red Bull?

FORMULA 1 · NOW

5 **British boxer Francesca Hennessy is in talks for an undisputed world title fight against Dina Thorslund later this year.**

The fight for the bantamweight world title is expected to take place in the United Kingdom. It would be a massive bout for Hennessy on home soil.

ON AIR – How exciting for Francesca Hennessy! Do you think she can become undisputed world champion?

BOXING · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A delightful trend sees people rediscovering the simple joy of 'letterboxing' in the countryside.**
It's a charming outdoor pursuit where participants follow clues to find hidden boxes containing a unique stamp and logbook, then leave their own mark before re-hiding it for the next adventurer.
- 2 Experts suggest that the subtle art of 'arranging household items by colour' can be surprisingly therapeutic.**
Apparently, creating visually pleasing colour gradients with books, spices, or even socks can bring a sense of order and calm to our living spaces.
- 3 A study reveals that 'watching short videos of cute animals' can actually boost productivity at work.**
Researchers found that a brief dose of cuteness can improve focus and attention, making us more efficient in our tasks afterwards. Who knew?
- 4 The delightful practice of 'foraging for wild berries and mushrooms' is experiencing a quiet renaissance.**
More and more people are connecting with nature by learning to identify and gather edible treasures from local woodlands and hedgerows, always with caution, of course!
- 5 It turns out that 'singing in the shower' isn't just fun; it's genuinely good for your well-being.**
The warm, enclosed space enhances acoustics, making our voices sound better, which in turn can reduce stress and boost mood. So belt it out!
- 6 A charming new app helps users 'identify local birds by their song', making morning walks even more engaging.**
Simply point your phone towards the sound, and the app will tell you which feathered friend is serenading you, perfect for budding ornithologists.
- 7 Research indicates that 'spending time near water' – be it a lake, river, or even a fountain – can significantly reduce stress.**
The gentle sounds and visual flow of water are thought to have a calming effect on our minds, promoting relaxation and well-being.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're peeling vegetables, even if we know it's not strictly necessary?

ANSWER: PEELING THEM OVER THE KITCHEN SINK, LETTING THE WATER RUN, EVEN WHEN THERE'S A BIN RIGHT NEXT TO US!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a lovely, fresh slice of pizza. What is it?

ANSWER: FOLDING THE SLICE IN HALF BEFORE TAKING THE FIRST BITE.

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes a particular 'smell in a garden' just instantly brings back a flood of memories from your childhood, or a lovely summer's day?

Perhaps it's the scent of freshly cut grass, or a particular type of rose, or even damp earth after a shower. What garden smell takes you back, and what memory does it conjure up?

- We all have those 'little everyday objects' that we couldn't do without, even if they seem insignificant to others, don't we?

It could be a favourite mug, a particular pen, or a very specific kitchen gadget. What's that one unassuming item in your life that you absolutely rely on, and why is it so indispensable?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** A group of owls is called a parliament.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Pigs are unable to look up at the sky due to the structure of their necks.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£25 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.8 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The average cloud weighs around 550 tons, roughly the same as 100 elephants.
- The world's oldest known living tree is a bristlecone pine named Methuselah, estimated to be over 4,800 years old.
- Butterflies taste with their feet.
- The 'king' in a deck of playing cards is the only one without a moustache.
- A bolt of lightning is five times hotter than the surface of the sun.
- The shortest complete sentence in the English language is 'I am'.
- Bubble wrap was originally intended to be used as wallpaper.
- Hawaii is the only U.S. state that grows coffee commercially.

On this day

Day 233 of the year, 132 days left in 2026. Today Christian Feast Day: Abraham of Smolensk (Eastern Orthodox Church); Christian Feast Day: Bernard of Alzira; Christian Feast Day: Cyriaca; Christian Feast Day: Euprepus of Verona. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1939 — James Burton, American Hall of Fame guitarist
- 1962 — Cleo King, American actress
- 1986 — Brooks Wheelan, American comedian and actor
- 1991 — Jesse Rutherford, American singer and songwriter
- 1975 — Alicia Witt, American actress and musician
- 1978 — Alan Lee, Irish footballer and coach
- 1968 — Dina Carroll, English singer-songwriter
- 1984 — Neil Dexter, South African cricketer

THE DAY TODAY

- 1991 — Coup attempt against Mikhail Gorbachev collapses.
- 1995 — Atlantic Southeast Airlines Flight 529, an Embraer EMB 120 Brasilia, attempts to divert to West Georgia Regional Airport after the left engine fails, but the aircraft crashes in Carroll County near Carrollton, Georgia, killing nine of the 29 people on board.
- 1994 — Royal Air Maroc Flight 630 crashes in Douar Izounine, Morocco, killing all 44 people on board.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1140 — Song dynasty general Yue Fei defeats an army led by Jin dynasty general Wuzhu at the Battle of Yancheng during the Jin–Song Wars.
- 1986 — Carbon dioxide gas erupts from volcanic Lake Nyos in Cameroon, killing up to 1,800 people within a 20-kilometre (12 mi) range.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1991 — Latvia declares renewal of its full independence after its occupation by the Soviet Union since 1940.

1983 — Philippine opposition leader Benigno Aquino Jr. is assassinated at Manila International Airport (now renamed Ninoy Aquino International Airport in his honor).

- 1918 — World War I: The Second Battle of the Somme begins.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 234 of the year, 131 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Immaculate Heart of Mary (Roman Catholic calendar of 1960); Christian feast day: John Kemble; Christian feast day: Queenship of Mary; Christian feast day: Blessed Symeon Lukach. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1967 — Adewale Akinnuoye-Agbaje, English actor
- 1994 — Israel Broussard, American actor
- 1936 — Chuck Brown, American singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer (died 2012)
- 1936 — Dale Hawkins, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2010)
- 1973 — Howie Dorough, American singer-songwriter and dancer
- 1986 — Stephen Ireland, Irish footballer
- 1967 — Ty Burrell, American actor and comedian
- 1939 — Valerie Harper, American actress (died 2019)

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1978 — The District of Columbia Voting Rights Amendment is passed by the U.S. Congress, although it is never ratified by a sufficient number of states.
- 2006 — Pulkovo Aviation Enterprise Flight 612 crashes near the Russian border over eastern Ukraine, killing all 170 people on board.
- 2004 — Versions of The Scream and Madonna, two paintings by Edvard Munch, are stolen at gunpoint from a museum in Oslo, Norway.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2006 — Grigori Perelman is awarded the Fields Medal for his proof of the Poincaré conjecture in mathematics but refuses to accept the medal.
- 1962 — The OAS attempts to assassinate French president Charles de Gaulle.

Coming to cinemas

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar

AUGUST 2026

22–23

Belgian Grand Prix (F1)